

Cultural Capital and Academic Achievement: The Role of Family and Social Backgrounds in Shaping Academic Performance among Banaras Hindu University (BHU) Students.

Author 1:

Abhishek Chaturvedi

Research Scholar, Sociology

Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi, India

Email: abhichaturvedi75.sociology.2024@bhu.ac.in

Author 2:

Alok Tripathi

Research Scholar

Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi, India

ABSTRACT:

This qualitative research explores the role of cultural capital in determining the academic success of the Social Science, Arts and Commerce undergraduate students at Banaras Hindu University (BHU), India. Based on Pierre Bourdieu's theoretical framework, it examines the way students' social background and institutional conventions intersect to produce diverse academic engagement. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 36 purposively selected students and thematic coding was used for data analysis. The results depict a stream-wise variation in the nature of dispositions within the access to cultural capital and the conversion of cultural capital, such that the students of Social Science are more confident about their academic work, more active in the class, and more recognised by the institution as compared to Arts and Commerce. Education in English and linguistic cultural capital are institutions of privilege which are unevenly allocated among the streams, accompanied by first-generation learners in Arts and Commerce. It underscores the differential and selective recognition of students at the institutional level where dominance favouritism in linguistic styles and familiarity with institutional norms is rewarded. Although the students do mobilise to try to obtain cultural capital in a variety of ways, family background, language and previous education still predominate as determinants of academic life. It contends that success in the field of education is impacted by socially passed resources and advocates for institutional reflexivity and pedagogical reorientation to recognise pan-cultural particulars and to facilitate inclusive learning environments. The results add to the literature on cultural capital in India and dialogue with methodological discussions on the representation of qualitative findings.

Keywords: academic achievement, cultural capital, higher education, parental education, social inequalities, educational credentials, family backgrounds.

INTRODUCTION:

Academic achievement plays a crucial role in higher education to the societies of today, as it is closely related to social mobility, occupational attainment, and longterm economic security. The role of universities is not limited to the mere transmission of knowledge and skills; they also act as prominent institutional agents through which social status, credentials, and life opportunities are being redistributed. Higher education commonly acted as a meritocratic field wherein individual talent and hard work led to success; however, sociological studies reveal that academic performance

is largely influenced by family backgrounds and social origins of students as well as their access to culturally valuable resources. Consequently, disparities in academic results are often indicative of the underlying social inequalities rather than being solely attributed to differences in individual capabilities (Sullivan, 2001). In the field of sociology of education, the theoretical framework of Pierre Bourdieu concerning cultural capital serves as an instrument to trace the reproduction of social inequalities via education systems. Cultural capital is the set of non-economic resources, e.g., knowledge, skills, language abilities, dispositions, and educational credentials, that are unequally distributed among different social groups and are implicitly favoured in formal education. Bourdieu identified three interconnected aspects of cultural capital: embodied, objectified, and institutionalised. Embodied cultural capital refers to the extent to which one has adopted certain values, has academic inclinations, certain ways of expression, and intellectual skills which have been acquired through the primary socialisation within the family. Objectified cultural capital denotes the material cultural goods that include books, learning tools, and various means of access to educational resources. Institutionalised cultural capital stands for the educational qualifications which are formally recognised, in particular, parental education, that gives social and academic legitimacy and value in the contexts of the school (Jin et al., 2024).

A significant number of empirical studies have shown that cultural capital has a determinative effect on academic success, as schooling systems are oriented towards privileging cultural skills that emanate the norms of the middle and upper-class. Students from more highly educated families are more likely to have the language skills, academic orientations, and knowledge of institutional expectations that are rewarded in universities. Meta-analyses and comparative analyses indicate parental education and educational expectations as two significant predictors of student achievement within different education systems (Tan, 2017), both of which can be considered institutionalised forms of cultural capital. In addition, recent literature on cultural capital stresses that everyday family behaviors, parental socialisation, and family learning environments play a reinforcing role in its intergenerational transmission as well as in enduring academic disparities in children's education (Urdan et al., 2007). With the global mass expansion of higher education, the scramble for academic success has become more intense, and family backgrounds have become more prominent. Studies show that even after formal degree access has been secured, students' academic performance in higher education continues to be heavily influenced by parental education, socio-economic status and family engagement (Considine & Zappalà, 2002). These results undermine the presumption that higher education serves to equalise or thresholds rather than contributing to cultural mechanisms of reproducing the inequalities of society. Parental influence on academic success does not weaken after the move to higher education. Reviews on higher education indicate that parents' involvement, emotional support and educational aspirations continue to influence students participation, motivation attitude and completion (Göbel & Preusche, 2019). What's more, children from families possessing greater cultural and educational capital tend to harbour higher educational ambitions, have a greater sense of what educational institutions are about, and know what to expect from them. In contrast, students belonging to lower social class and educational groups encounter cultural and structural barriers such as reduced access to advising, less knowledge about what students are supposed to do to be academically successful, and greater difficulty in navigating institutional norms, all having a negative impact on their academic success (Gupta, 2022). Such trends indicate that attainment in HE is a socially situated process rather than the 'raw' outcome of individual commitment or ability. Increasingly, empirical research also confirms that there are good reasons to analyse academic success as a diverse sociological phenomenon. Studies across settings find that students' academic performance is shaped by the level of parental education, home learning environment, and cultural experiences. Cultural capital is also said to intersect with gender, socioeconomic status and family educational trajectories and course of study at university, creating differentiated academic outcomes and reproducing patterns of educational disadvantage (Munir et al., 2023). Findings such as these call attention to the necessity of context-specific research that investigates the ways in which cultural capital functions across particular institutional and social contexts.

Even though international studies on cultural capital and academic success were found in abundance, the same could not be said about how these processes are played out in Indian higher education. A large bulk of this research has taken place in the West, which possesses educational systems, forms of social stratification, and institutional cultures that differ markedly from those in India. Although these studies are interesting and provide some useful theoretical grounds, none of the conclusions drawn can be otherwise than qualified when applied to the Indian situation, which involves unique historical trajectories, social hierarchies and configurations of institutional. In addition, Indian studies have tended to focus on access to higher education, reservation policies, or general indicators of socioeconomic status, rather than the delicate cultural processes through which family background shapes university performance of students there. This gap in the

research is particularly important when considered against the background of the massive growth and diversification of higher education in India. With universities now drawing students from a wider range of social and economic groups, disparities in academic achievement remain. Global overview indicates that increasing access to higher education does not level the social playing field: family background and cultural capital still strongly shape academic world even once students have made the leap into post-secondary.

In this regard, the Banaras Hindu University (BHU) offers a very pertinent institutional space to analyse the nexus between cultural capital and educational attainment. BHU ranks among India's most elite and socially diverse public universities and attracts students of varying regional, socioeconomic, and educational backgrounds. The Survival of the Fittest: First-generation university students are also able to study alongside students from extremely well-educated families, in this socially stratified place, differences in cultural capital, will be very visible. Differences in parents' education and access to academic culture and institutional norms may lead to differential academic experiences and outcomes even across university settings. To conclude, we argue there has been insufficient application of Bourdieu's framework of cultural capital to the study of academic success at university in the Indian context. This absence hinders a more nuanced analysis of the ways in which everyday academic practices, institutional expectations, and assessment procedures contribute to the perpetuation of inequalities in education (O'Sullivan et al., 2018). Against this background, the current research, "The Cultural Capital and Socio-Economic Determinants of Academic Achievement: A Study of BHU Students, attempts to analyse the effect of cultural capital and family background on academic performance among the students of Banaras Hindu University. Based on Bourdieu's theoretical lens and relevant empirical studies, the research intends to investigate the level of cultural capital among BHU students and to know its association with academic achievement. Special emphasis is laid on the influence of parental education, family educational practices, and various types of cultural capital embodied, objectified and institutionalised on academic results. By placing academic performance within a sociological context, this study challenges individualistic interpretations of success and failure and draws attention to the structural and cultural conditions that determine education outcomes. In so doing, it adds to our understanding of educational inequality within Indian higher education and in doing so, provides insights that are applicable to sociological theory as well as educational policy. An insight into the workings of cultural capital in universities like BHU will be useful in the construction of institutional support systems, pedagogical strategies and policy initiatives that would lead to greater equity in academic achievement. The study, in sum, aims to argue that academic success in HE is not just a matter of individual talent but rather a socially constituted process influenced by family, culture, and institutional contexts.

LITERATURE REVIEW:

Theoretical Framework: Cultural Capital Theory:

The notion of cultural capital is key to Pierre Bourdieu's theory of social reproduction, which details the role of education systems in sustaining social inequalities through recognising and valuing the cultural knowledge of ruling social groups. Bourdieu have maintained that schools are cultural systems of transmission, in which certain types of knowledge, language, and ways of acting are made legitimate, and that conversion of social privilege into scholastic success occurs along with its mediatization as a meritocratic one (Bourdieu, 2018) and (Huang, 2019). Cultural capital is an important category of capital along with economic and social capital, but its impact is often less apparent because it is embedded in day to day activities and in symbolic evaluation.

Bourdieu distinguished three types of cultural capital: embodied, objectified, and institutionalised. Embodied cultural capital comprises ingrained dispositions, such as linguistic skills, educational confidence, learning styles, and cognitive approaches, which are acquired through socialisation primarily in the family from an early age. These dispositions influence how they shape students' habits as well as how students make sense of and respond to academic demands (Claussen & Osborne, 2012). Objectified cultural capital takes the form of material cultural goods, such as books, educational materials, and institutions for learning. While these materials enable learning, Bourdieu stressed that it is the embodied capacity to meaningfully engage with them that makes the difference (Jin et al., 2024). Institutionalised cultural capital, expressed as educational qualifications, especially parental education, has been viewed as a legitimate measure of skill and social value in the education system (Crosnoe & Benner, 2015).

Bourdieu's theoretical framework, while extremely influential, has rightly been critiqued and extended. Certain scholars will suggest that cultural capital is not the same in every place and the effects of it are filtered through the structures of institutions, the regimes of assessment and the national education systems (Jæger, 2011). In some accounts, cultural capital is identified as a modality of cultural mobility (instead of simply cultural reproduction) and, as such, even students based in the non-elite background are capable of garnering culturally valued skills through schooling (Breinholt & Jæger, 2020). In subsequent developments, a further differentiation between established cultural capital (highbrow possessions and practices) and emergent cultural capital (parent-child communication and educational engagement) is proposed to capture the dynamic process of influence involving cultural resources and academic outcomes (Breinholt & Jæger, 2020).

Cultural Capital and Academic Achievement:

Numerous empirical studies indicate that there is a strong association between cultural capital and educational success. Meta-analyses also show that the amount of cultural capital of students is positively related to their performance, although the strength of this relationship varies by indicator. Parental education and parental educational expectations, which were treated as two manifestations of institutionalised cultural capital, are identified as the most influential factors of academic performance (Farkas, 2018). These results are in line with Bourdieu's claim that schools privilege culturally legitimate competencies rather than cognitive ability per se.

Studies in multiple countries demonstrate universal and context-dependent influence of cultural capital on academic outcomes. Research in Europe and North America finds that students hailing from culturally rich families have greater academic success, especially in subjects that involve language skills and interpretation (Mikus et al., 2019). And works in China at the national scale also prove that cultural capital serves as a mediator between family background and academic achievement but its effects are modulated by examination systems and institutional standardisation (Paino & Renzulli, 2012).

Newer research also confirms that cultural capital takes motivational and behavioural routes. Cultural capital has been found to affect students' academic motivation, engagement, and retention, especially in highly competitive learning contexts (Daumiller & Hemi, 2025). Available evidence from Brazil and from cross-national datasets suggests that relational cultural capital - including parental communication, educational discussions, and emotional support - more frequently exerts a stronger influence on educational achievement than normative cultural resources per se (Mzidabi et al., 2024).

Current research is methodologically diverse, drawing on quantitative, qualitative and mixed-methods approaches. Mass surveys and meta-analyses supply authoritative evidence on broad trends, whereas qualitative research provides more nuanced accounts of how students both experience and convert cultural capital in routine academic practices (Ives & Castillo-Montoya, 2020). However, scholars highlight just how much of the literature concerns itself with school-level achievement, and that there is comparatively little to say about academic success within university, at least, in non-Western contexts (Burger & Naude, 2019).

Family Background and Academic Success:

Family background is a central way in which cultural capital is passed from generation to generation. Education and occupation of the parents are considered to be the best proxies of institutionalised cultural capital, as they represent both institutionalised cultural capital in the form of formal qualifications and the inclusion in academic related systems. There is a consistent body of evidence that indicates students with more educated parents perform better academically, even after controlling for economic factors (Fuller, 1987).

The transmission of cultural capital from one generation to the next is enacted through everyday family routines, including language, expectations for education, homework help, and exposure to academic norms. Research suggests that parental engagement influences students' educational goals, beliefs in their capabilities, and learning activities; however, it also contributes to widening disparities in academic success for the various social classes (Ross, 2016). Interestingly, these dynamics are at play even in postsecondary education, disputing the belief that familial influence wanes as students exit high school (Goegan & Daniels, 2019).

The activation and effectiveness of cultural capital are further conditioned by family SES. Although material economic resources contribute to acquiring educational resources and private assistance whereas immaterial cultural resources such as parental expectations and support in education influence the educational performance (Tan, 2017). Comparative research reveals that the weight of family background on differences in education varies between societies, cultural mechanisms however always contribute to reproducing inequalities (Grätz, 2018).

Social Background and Academic Performance:

Academic success is also influenced by wider societal contexts beyond the household. Peer groups and social networks shape access to academic information, institutional navigation abilities, and sources of motivation, and as such, either amplify or attenuate advantages related to cultural capital (Farkas, 2018). Students embedded in academic peer networks have a greater propensity to adopt institutional expectations and acquire resources for success in academia. Studies of indigenous and marginalised populations also show that home-institutional mismatches in cultural expectations contribute to under-performance academically, even where (formal) educational access is secured (Perales Franco & Mccowan, 2020).

Thus, academic achievement is determined by intersections between social background and other variables including gender, ethnicity, type of institution, and assessment regimes. Research indicates that the effect of cultural capital is not independent but relates to structural factors such as exam systems, regional disparities and institutional selectiveness (Tompsett & Knoester, 2023). From this multi-dimensional perspective calls for sociological investigation that transcend individual and explore how family, culture and social structure separately and collectively influence academic success.

METHODOLOGY:

This research is a qualitative, interpretive study, which investigates the influences of cultural capital on university students' academic confidence, classroom interaction and institutional recognition in different disciplines. This study is theoretically informed by Pierre Bourdieu's notions of cultural capital, habitus and field, which enable an analysis into how students' social backgrounds and the institutional norms interrelate to shape dissimilar academic engagement. A qualitative methodology is appropriate for this study as cultural capital is part of lived experiences, dispositions and making sense phenomena that cannot be quantified.

This research was carried out in BHU, a central university with heterogeneous social, linguistic and educational composition. BHU makes an appropriate institution for the study of cultural capital given the presence of both students from privileged educational backgrounds, as well as those who are first generation learners and those who have been schooled in vernacular and government institutions. The research was conducted with students from Social Sciences, Arts and Commerce, as these three streams vary of their course pedagogy, type of assessment and the extent to which they depend on linguistic and symbolic skills.

A purposive sampling procedure was followed to recruit participants with diverse academic backgrounds and experiences. Stream of education, family educational background and medium of schooling were focused upon. Utilising departmental connections and peer referrals, 36 students were recruited for this study. Of these, 14 students (38.9%) were from Social Sciences, 12 (33.3%) from Arts and 10 (27.8%) from Commerce, providing an equal distribution across streams. Sampling continued until thematic saturation was reached, i.e., when no new analytical insights were emerging from further interviews.

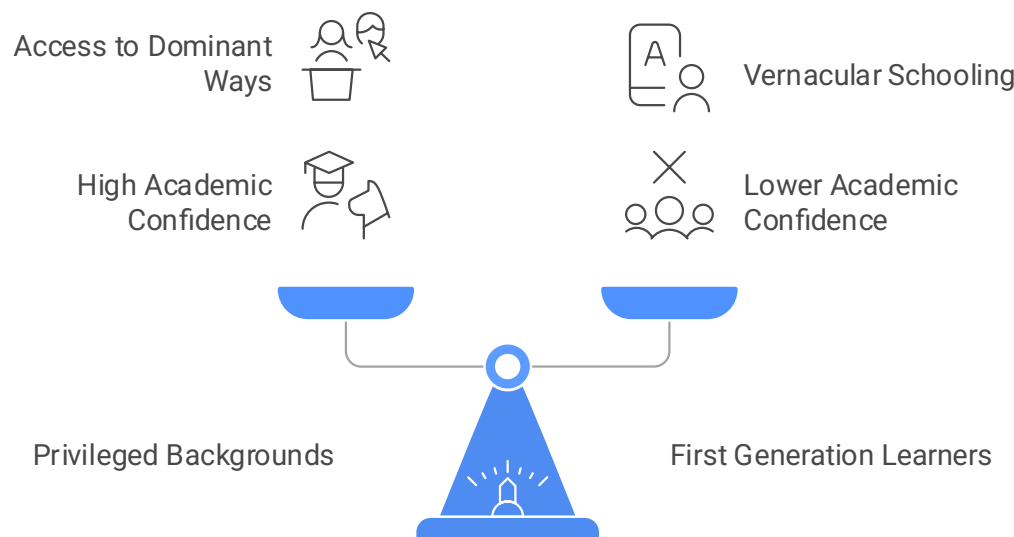
The data were gathered through semi-structured interviews with the duration ranging from 45 to 70 minutes. Depending on participant's comfort level, interviews were conducted in Hindi or English. The interview schedule covered areas such as family background in education, school life experiences, use of language, classroom attendance, interaction with teacher and perceptions about academic confidence and recognition. The analysis of the data takes the form of a thematic coding procedure, where transcript of interviews are coded inductively and then they are categorised analytically into embodiments of cultural capital, institutional recognition and (cultural) adaptation strategies. While the study is qualitative, frequencies and percentage were computed out of thematic coding for better analytical clarity and comparative

interpretation

across

academic streams.

Cultural Capital's Impact on Academic Engagement



RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS:

The following analysis, summarised in three aggregated tables, clearly outlines the stream-wise differences in the distribution and functioning of cultural capital. These differences are not simply personal characteristics but are rather reflective of how closely institutional expectations converge with specific types of embodied cultural capital.

Table 1 presents the students in terms of their academic and cultural capital in each stream. Students from Social Sciences have highest academic confidence (50.0%) and comfortable class participation (57.1%) as compared to Arts and Commerce. But among the Arts students 33.3% and Commerce students 30.0% felt very much academically confident. In Bourdieuan terms, these distinctions can be read as Social Science curricula frequently favour discussion, debate, and critical thinking, which advantage students who already know how to do these things based on family and schooling practice. This, in turn, enables their embodied cultural capital to be more easily seen and affirmed in the field of the academy.

The table also suggests that English-medium education, as a form of linguistic cultural capital, remains a privilege in itself that is not uniformly distributed across streams. A total of 42.9% of Social Sciences students and 40.0% of Commerce students had brought with them background in English medium education but only 25.0% of Arts students. Instead it is the first-generation learners who are the highest concentrated in Arts (66.7%) and Commerce (60.0%). This sequence shows that it might be easier for the students taking the two latter streams to enter university without having been conversant with dominant academic codes, at least to some extent, which weakens their confidence and participation.

Table 1: Academic and Cultural Capital Profile by Academic Stream (N = 36)

Academic Stream	High Academic Confidence (%)	Comfortable Participation(%)	English-Medium Schooling (%)	First-Generation Students (%)
Social Sciences (n=14)	50.0	57.1	42.9	50.0
Arts (n=12)	33.3	33.3	25.0	66.7
Commerce (n=10)	30.0	30.0	40.0	60.0

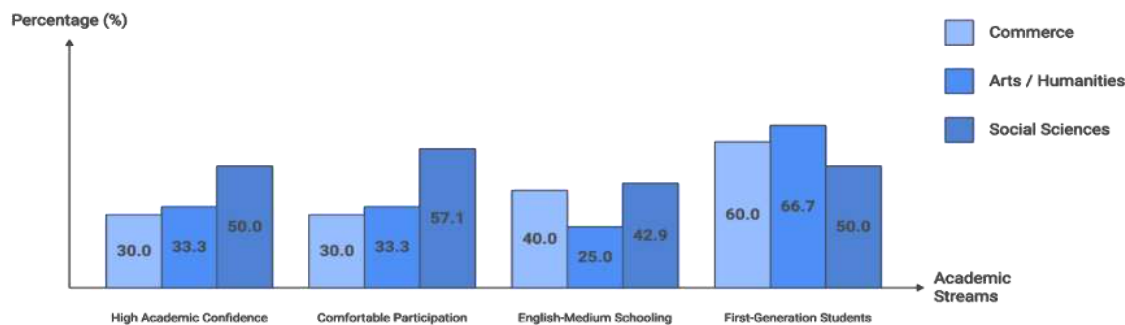
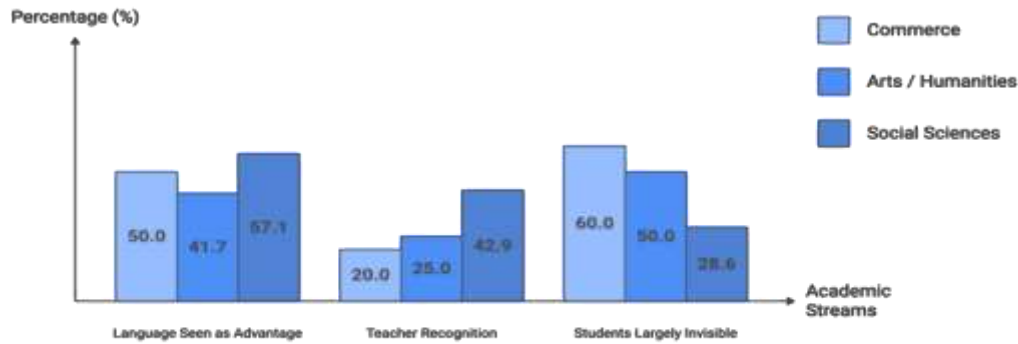

Academic and Cultural Capital Profile by Academic Stream

Table 2 analyses in more depth language, recognition, and institution/profession experience. Language is considered an academic asset by a majority of Social Science students (57.1%), but this is not the case for Arts students (41.7%). A similar trend emerges for teacher recognition: (42.9%) of Social Sciences students stated that they had teacher recognition almost always for only (25.0%) in Arts and 20.0% in Commerce. A similar pattern emerges: invisibility in class is relatively prevalent among Commerce (60.0%) and Arts (50.0%) students.

These results suggest that institutional recognition is not neutral, but rather selective. Students who have dominant linguistic styles, who feel comfortable in academic ways of speaking, and who have knowledge of how institutions work are more likely to be seen, heard, and encouraged. Over time this recognition translates embodied cultural capital into symbolic capital, which reproduces academic hierarchies and justifies unequal outcomes under the guise of meritocracy. Those students who do not embody these characteristics often internalise silence and retreat deepening their isolation from even more academic resources and mentorship.

Table 2: Language, Recognition, and Institutional Experience by Stream (N = 36)

Academic Stream	Language Seen as Advantage (%)	Teacher Recognition (Frequent %)	Students Largely Invisible (%)
Social Sciences	57.1	42.9	28.6
Arts	41.7	25.0	50.0
Commerce	50.0	20.0	60.0



Language, Recognition, and Institutional Experience by Stream

Cultural capital strategies of adaptation and perceived effect on cultural capital in table 3 denote both agency and constraint. In all streams of studies, the students, however, are active in seeking for cultural capital after joining the university. The most common bullying-victim strategy is self reading while taking notes, which is used by (61.1%) of all respondents, followed by peer imitation (52.8%) and enacting language practices (44.4%). The most active users of these techniques are the Social Science students, especially Self-Reading (71.4%) and Faculty Interaction (42.9%) while Arts and Commerce students show less faculty-consultation, due to factors of reticence and social distance, although they are the second largest group to consult the faculty after the SC students.

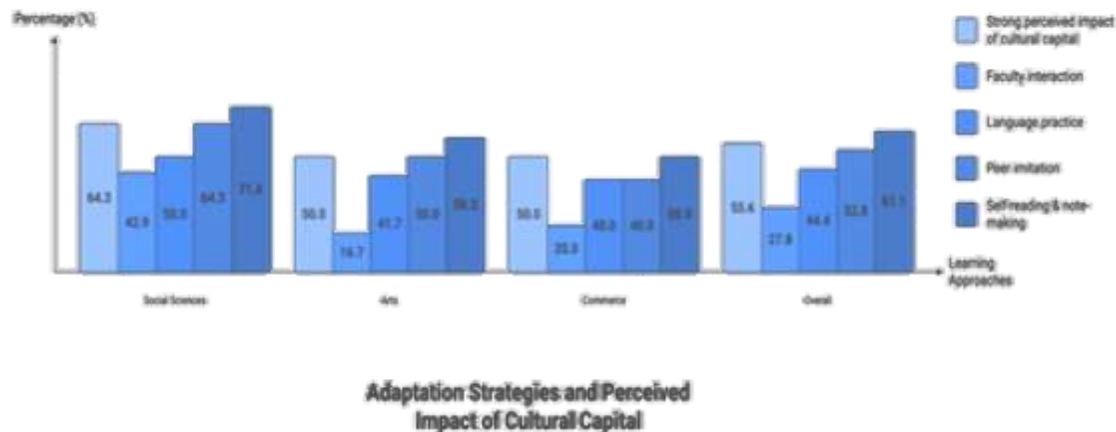
Nevertheless, the influence of cultural capital is still perceived to be great. In total, 55.6% of the respondents reported that cultural capital has a strong impact on academic performance, and social science students again had the highest proportion (64.3%). So it seems that you can adjust, but it's a painful and uneven process. Students have to put in extra time and effort just to get to some level of acceptability, while others walk into their academic work already possessing those skills.

Altogether, the findings suggest that cultural capital functions as a structuring principle within higher education affecting confidence, participation, recognition and academic results within all three streams. The university thus appears as not only a site of knowledge production/transmission but also a social field which values certain cultural dispositions. While agentic motives are evident in adaptation strategies, family background, language, and prior education based structural disparities continue to govern academic life.

Table 3: Cultural Capital Adaptation Strategies and Perceived Impact

(N = 36; Multiple Response)

Indicator	Social Sciences (%)	Arts (%)	Commerce (%)	Overall (%)
Self-reading & note-making	71.4	58.3	50.0	61.1
Peer imitation	64.3	50.0	40.0	52.8
Language practice	50.0	41.7	40.0	44.4
Faculty interaction	42.9	16.7	20.0	27.8
Strong perceived impact of cultural capital	64.3	50.0	50.0	55.6



CONCLUSION:

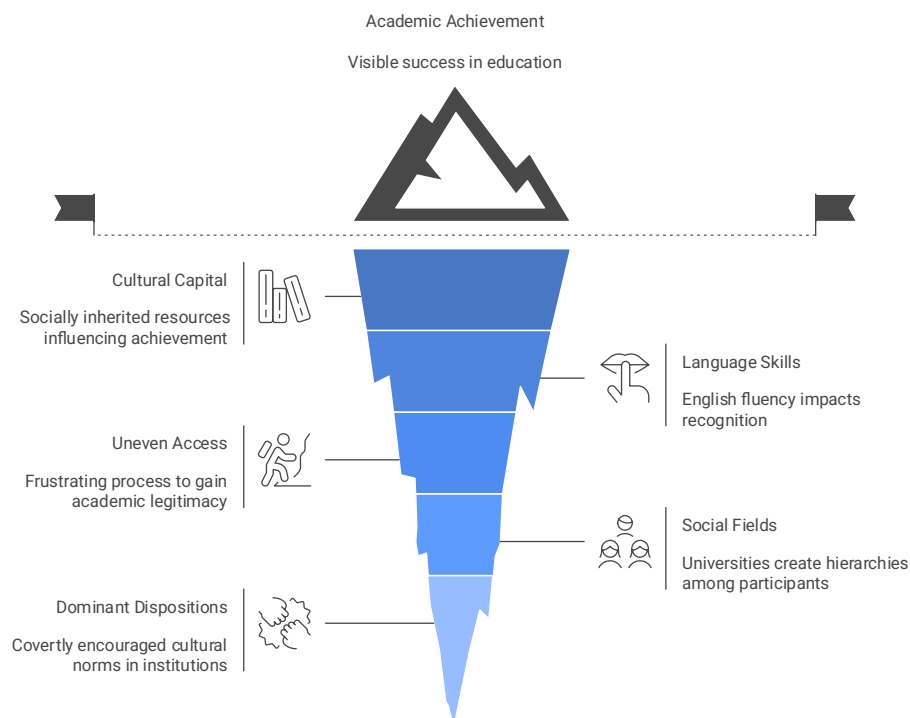
This study makes an important contribution by revealing the processes through which cultural capital functions as a critical, if an elusive, component that shapes academic self-confidence, classroom performance and institutional acknowledgement in higher education. Studying students from the disciplines of Social Sciences, Arts and Commerce in Banaras Hindu University, this paper argues that achievement in the academic field is not only the result of one's inherent intellect or material effort but is also influenced by socially inherited resources such as language skills, educational background of family and access to dominant academic ways of thinking. The results highlight the enduring utility of Bourdieusian accounts for making sense of reproductions of inequalities in nominally meritocratic educational fields.

What is significant about the results of this study tightly binds up three closely related "categories." First, students in Social Sciences hold relatively higher academic self-confidence and classroom participation, which may indicate that their embodied cultural capital is closer to institutional expectations. Second, language serves as an important gatekeeping device, with English-medium education and fluency providing greater visibility and recognition, and vernacular-background students, mainly in Arts and Commerce, facing hesitance and marginalisation. Three, while students are engaged in active strategies to accrue cultural capital on their way to university, the process is uneven and frustrating and often they must do double labor in order to be able to have academic legitimacy.

Outside the immediate purview of the study, these results have further implications for the study of stratification in Indian higher education system. The evidence, therefore, demonstrates that universities are not just knowledge transmitters, but are also 'social fields [which] create hierarchies among their participants, in terms of recognition and social worth, within and through subtle processes of inclusion and exclusion'. Where dominant cultural dispositions (such as speaking English well, heterosexuality and middle class status as unearned indicators of merit were models of such cultural dispositions) are covertly encouraged in institutional practice, this form of 'disability' within struck racial, class and genderbased inequalities under the sunny of neutrality and meritocracy. To understand and counter educational disadvantage, then, it's not enough to focus on access and enrolment: we need to politicise pedagogic practices, assessment regimes and classroom exchanges themselves.

The study is significant in that it combines qualitative depth with systematic thematic distribution, allowing for stream-wise comparison without reducing lived experience to statistics. In presenting qualitative results in a way that can be turned into analytically productive tables, the study connects interpretive sociology with empirical clarity, providing a methodological strategy especially suited to analyses of culture, education and inequality. Doing this, it makes empirical contributions to the growing literature on cultural capital in the Indian context and at the same time engages with methodological debates on the transparent and rigorous presentation of qualitative findings.

Cultural Capital Shapes Academic Outcomes.



The study also opens up several new directions for later investigations. Further research might include exploring professional and technical disciplines; investigating cultural capital acquisition longitudinally during students' academic journeys; or examining the influence of faculty perceptions and institutional policies on practices of recognition. Comparative research among universities and regions would also contribute to broadening the national and global systems of educational stratification implicated in these results.

Finally, the study advocates for "the development of institutional reflexivity and pedagogical reorientation". Universities must realise that equality is not achieved simply through formal inclusion but that it demands active work to value diverse cultural backgrounds, to support first-generation students, and to dissociate academic merit from constricted cultural norms. Higher education can only progress towards becoming a true inclusive site of learning and social change by recognising and confronting the cultural aspects of inequality.

REFERENCES:

- Bourdieu, P. (2018). *Structures, Habitus, Practices* (pp. 31–45). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780429497643-2>
- Breinholt, A., & Jæger, M. M. (2020). How does cultural capital affect educational performance: Signals or skills? *The British Journal of Sociology*, 71(1), 28–46. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-4446.12711>
- Burger, A., & Naude, L. (2019). In their own words - students' perceptions and experiences of academic success in higher education. *Educational Studies*, 46(5), 624–639. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03055698.2019.1626699>
- Claussen, S., & Osborne, J. (2012). Bourdieu's notion of cultural capital and its implications for the science curriculum. *Science Education*, 97(1), 58–79. <https://doi.org/10.1002/sce.21040>
- Considine, G., & Zappalà, G. (2002). The influence of social and economic disadvantage in the academic performance of school students in Australia. *Journal of Sociology*, 38(2), 129–148. <https://doi.org/10.1177/144078302128756543>
- Crosnoe, R., & Benner, A. D. (2015). *Children at School*. 1–37. <https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118963418.childpsy407>

- Daumiller, M., & Hemi, A. (2025). Peer relationships and student motivation: Theoretical and methodological approaches, empirical evidence, and future directions. *The British Journal of Educational Psychology*, 95(4), 905–923. <https://doi.org/10.1111/bjep.70030>
- Farkas, G. (2018). *Family, Schooling, and Cultural Capital* (pp. 3–38). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-76694-2_1
- Fuller, B. (1987). What School Factors Raise Achievement in the Third World? *Review of Educational Research*, 57(3), 255–292. <https://doi.org/10.3102/00346543057003255>
- Göbel, K., & Preusche, Z. M. (2019). Emotional school engagement among minority youth: The relevance of cultural identity, perceived discrimination, and perceived support. *Intercultural Education*, 30(5), 547–563. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14675986.2019.1616263>
- Goegan, L. D., & Daniels, L. M. (2019). Academic Success for Students in Postsecondary Education: The Role of Student Characteristics and Integration. *Journal of College Student Retention: Research, Theory & Practice*, 23(3), 659–685. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1521025119866689>
- Grätz, M. (2018). Competition in the Family: Inequality between Siblings and the Intergenerational Transmission of Educational Advantage. *Sociological Science*, 5(11), 246–269. <https://doi.org/10.15195/v5.a11>
- Gupta, A. (2022). Revisiting educational advantage and social class: a Bourdieusian analysis of middle-class parents' investment in private schooling and shadow education. *British Journal of Sociology of Education*, ahead-of-print(ahead-of-print), 26–42. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2022.2126824>
- Huang, X. (2019). Understanding Bourdieu - Cultural Capital and Habitus. *Review of European Studies*, 11(3), 45. <https://doi.org/10.5539/res.v11n3p45>
- Ives, J., & Castillo-Montoya, M. (2020). First-Generation College Students as Academic Learners: A Systematic Review. *Review of Educational Research*, 90(2), 139–178. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0034654319899707>
- Jæger, M. M. (2011). Does Cultural Capital Really Affect Academic Achievement? New Evidence from Combined Sibling and Panel Data. *Sociology of Education*, 84(4), 281–298. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0038040711417010>
- Jin, H., Jiao, S., Ma, X., & Xia, Y. (2024). Cultural capital as a predictor of school success: evidence and gender differences in Chinese middle schools. *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, 11(1). <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-024-03382-x>
- Mikus, K., Tieben, N., & Schober, P. S. (2019). Children's conversion of cultural capital into educational success: the symbolic and skill-generating functions of cultural capital. *British Journal of Sociology of Education*, 41(2), 197–217. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2019.1677454>
- Munir, J., Jamal, B., Faiza, M., Iqbal, K., & Daud, S. (2023). The Impact of Socio-economic Status on Academic Achievement. *Journal of Social Sciences Review*, 3(2), 695–705. <https://doi.org/10.54183/jssr.v3i2.308>
- Mzidabi, J., Goudeau, S., Alexopoulos, T., Easterbrook, M. J., Claes, N., Delès, R., & Rouet, J. (2024). Unequal homework: The hidden forces of social class contexts and parental self-efficacy in shaping educational outcomes. *Journal of Social Issues*, 80(4), 1315–1344. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12656>
- O'Sullivan, K., Robson, J., & Winters, N. (2018). 'I feel like I have a disadvantage': how socio-economically disadvantaged students make the decision to study at a prestigious university. *Studies in Higher Education*, 44(9), 1676–1690. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079.2018.1460591>
- Paino, M., & Renzulli, L. A. (2012). Digital Dimension of Cultural Capital. *Sociology of Education*, 86(2), 124–138. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0038040712456556>
- Passi, P., Miotti, A., Carli, P. O., & De Marchi, M. (1989). Tramonte screw for replacement of single teeth. *Giornale Di Stomatologia e Di Ortognatodonzia*, 8(2), 83–8.
- Perales Franco, C., & Mccowan, T. (2020). Rewiring higher education for the Sustainable Development Goals: the case of the Intercultural University of Veracruz, Mexico. *Higher Education*, 81(1), 69–88. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-020-00525-2>
- Rogers, M. F., & Swartz, D. (1999). Culture and Power: The Sociology of Pierre Bourdieu. *Contemporary Sociology*, 28(2), 234. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2654908>
- Ross, T. R. (2016). The differential effects of parental involvement on high school completion and postsecondary attendance. *Education Policy Analysis Archives*, 24(30), 30. <https://doi.org/10.14507/epaa.24.2030>
- Sullivan, A. (2001). Cultural Capital and Educational Attainment. *Sociology*, 35(4), 893–912. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0038038501035004006>

- Swedberg, R. (2011). The Economic Sociologies of Pierre Bourdieu. *Cultural Sociology*, 5(1), 67–82. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1749975510389712>
- Tan, C. Y. (2017). Do parental attitudes toward and expectations for their children's education and future jobs matter for their children's school achievement? *British Educational Research Journal*, 43(6), 1111–1130. <https://doi.org/10.1002/berj.3303>
- Tompsett, J., & Knoester, C. (2023). Family socioeconomic status and college attendance: A consideration of individual-level and school-level pathways. *PLOS ONE*, 18(4), e0284188. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0284188>
- Urdan, T., Schoenfelder, E., & Solek, M. (2007). Students' perceptions of family influences on their academic motivation: A qualitative analysis. *European Journal of Psychology of Education*, 22(1), 7–21. <https://doi.org/10.1007/bf03173686>
- Wacquant, L. J. D. (1987). Symbolic Violence and the Making of the French Agriculturalist: An Enquiry into Pierre Bourdieu's Sociology. *The Australian and New Zealand Journal of Sociology*, 23(1), 65–88. <https://doi.org/10.1177/144078338702300105>

Appendix: Interview Tool

The following interview tool was designed so as to interrogate the main themes of the research:

Family and Social Background:

- ☐ How do you think your family's educational background influences your academic journey?
- ☐ To what extent do your parents talk to you about your academic journey (e.g., how your studies are going, what you're studying, whether you're facing any difficulties in your studies, etc.)?
- ☐ How do your family members view your academic goals and ambitions? Do they support you in this?
- ☐ Do you feel that your family's social and economic situation affects your experiences and opportunities? If so, how?

Cultural Capital:

- ☐ What do you understand by "cultural capital"? Have you ever heard of it? In your understanding, what is it, and does it actually impact students' academic lives?
- ☐ Do you feel that your language, educational background, and other cultural experiences influence your academic performance?
- ☐ Does the language used in class (e.g., English or Hindi) affect your class participation and confidence?
- ☐ Have you ever experienced or faced challenges where you couldn't meet academic expectations because your family's educational background wasn't as strong, especially in higher education?

Academic Engagement and Confidence:

- ☐ How confident do you feel about your academic work at university? Are there any specific subjects or areas where you feel more or less confident?
- ☐ In which subject do you feel most invested, and why?
- ☐ What do you think, do your professors and the educational system recognize your academic efforts and abilities?

Academic Engagement and Confidence:

- ☐ How do you usually interact with your professors and classmates, especially during lectures or discussions?
- ☐ What do you think, how does your educational background (e.g., first-generation learner) shape your ability to participate in academic settings?
- ☐ Have you ever faced challenges navigating through institutional norms or classroom practices? If yes, what strategies did you use to overcome these challenges?

Adaptation and Coping Strategies:

- ☐ Which strategies helped you cope with the challenges you faced in your academic journey?
- ☐ How do you manage the expectations of your family and your academic commitments?
- ☐ What steps do you take to enhance your academic skills and cultural capital (e.g., self-reading, faculty interaction)?

Impact of Cultural Capital:

- ☐ In your opinion, how important is cultural capital in determining academic success at university?
- ☐ Have you noticed any differences between students with similar backgrounds and those from different family backgrounds in academia? If yes, what are the key differences?

Future Outlook:

- ☐ What do you think, how can universities recognise and value different types of cultural capital to support students from diverse backgrounds?
- ☐ What changes would you like to see in educational systems to make them more inclusive for students coming from various backgrounds?

These questions were designed to explore various aspects of the cultural capital, academic confidence, engagement and institutional recognition, which is in line with the theoretical assumption made by Pierre Bourdieu. The semi structured method provided the respondents with the space to express subtle views and contributed to a detailed description of the lived experiences of the students in different academic streams.